

areas fairly quickly as the central areas saturate. Again, patience is the key factor in terms of returns—and certainly, residential real estate should not be seen as a get-rich-quick magic trick, because it isn't.

"Rather than going for metros, main cities, one should look out for suburbs where property prices are still pocket-friendly. Also, a wait-and-watch approach might not be the best option as prices in these areas will also rise in another 1-2 years," says L.C. Mittal, Director of commercial real estate developers Motia Group.

People tend to invest in properties in their hometowns because of a familiar landscape. Tier II and Tier III cities are the new growth engines and are bound to see property and rental values go up in the future—especially if they have good amenities. If someone is stuck with properties in Tier II or Tier III cities that offer low rental income, there are strategies to improve their situation. "To monetise properties better, one can consider converting the property into alternate assets with some investment. For instance, student accommodation can be a big market," says Goel. She adds, "If there are tourist places, one can also mull converting the property into a bed and breakfast."

Millennials should identify whether the city they are currently invested in is slated for major infrastructure upgrades that can significantly boost overall valuations. "If such developments are in the offing, holding on makes a lot of sense," adds Phondge.

The housing crisis has wider socio-economic implications. For instance, owning a home has traditionally been a pathway to upward social mobility. With fewer young people achieving home ownership, social mobility stagnates, potentially leading to or deepening inequalities. Further, the rise of

young people priced out of the buying market puts additional pressure on the rental market, potentially leading to rent hikes and a shortage of affordable rental units.

One must also understand that buying a home is not an easy task. You need to do proper math before zeroing in on one. Besides, one must also assess one's financial situation to find out the home loan amount you can afford. Adhil Shetty, Chief Executive Officer of BankBazaar.com, says, "Lenders sanction a loan based on your income. To find out the loan amount you can afford to repay, assess your monthly expenses, Cibil score, etc. Don't forget about the down payment—usually 20% of the prop-

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A DREAM DEFERRED, NOT DESTROYED

There is no doubt that the Indian housing market needs a correction to bridge the gap between aspiration and reality for millennials. While owning a home may become a more distant goal in the current scenario, it doesn't have to remain an unfulfilled dream. Govind Rai, Co-founder and CEO of real estate marketing firm Insomniacs Digital, says, "One should not be disheartened by the sudden price rise. Actually, there is no good or bad time to invest in a home, especially in India, at least for the next 10 years. One should rather start planning to

take a plunge. Whenever you are investing, plan for houses keeping the next 6 to 8 years in mind. Thus, wait and invest wisely. Remember, your salaries will grow, and your EMIs in a few years may not look as big as they may look today."

While experts believe that the real estate market is expected to see steady growth over the next decade, making home ownership a sound investment, one should capitalise on the price movement if they have a sound budget. However, on the flip side, to incentivise millennial home ownership in major cities, the government should also devise schemes and tax benefits that make buying a home in metros a more accessible proposition.

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